

CMUQ-IS Advising Resource Document

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1 Advisor Role and Resources

Every student at CMUQ is assigned an academic advisor to guide them in making consistent progress toward fulfilling their major requirements. Typically, the official advisor is a faculty member from the student's home department and is listed in both S3 and Stellic. In the Information Systems program, students receive a new advisor every year until graduation. They see a different advisor each year.

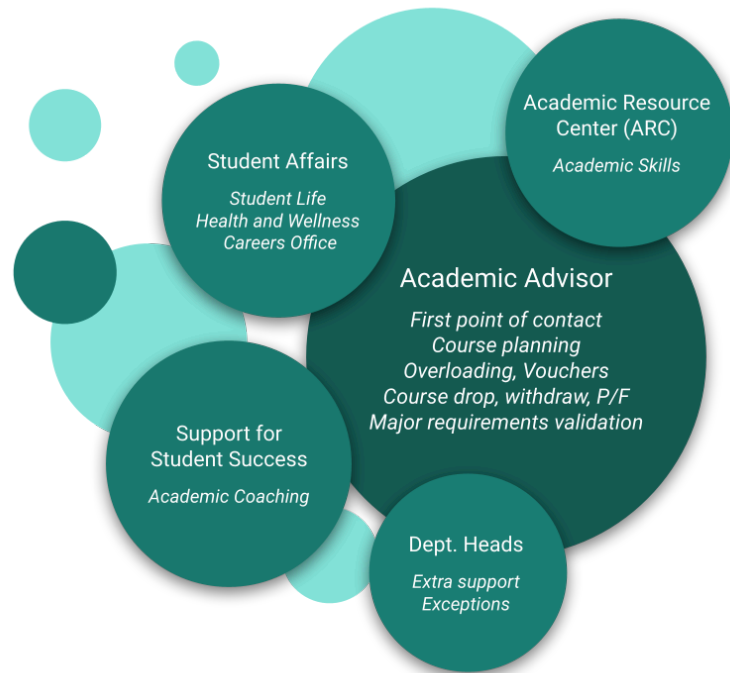
Advisors are integral to the student support system at CMUQ. Below is a summary of their key responsibilities, though this list is not exhaustive.

- **Help with planning courses to ensure progress towards graduation:** Advisors assist students in selecting appropriate courses each semester, ensuring they meet the necessary prerequisites and are on track to fulfill all major requirements, leading to timely graduation.
- Adding exceptions for courses in Stellic once they are approved by the appropriate department or faculty (e.g. counting senior theses for concentrations, placement exams for calculus courses, graduate versions of courses).
- **Adding exceptions for courses in Stellic once they are approved by the appropriate department or faculty:** Advisors facilitate the administrative process of updating Stellic, including adding exceptions such as counting senior theses towards concentrations, or substituting graduate versions of courses, after receiving approval from the relevant faculty or department.
- **Help students make decisions about keeping or dropping courses:** Advisors provide guidance on whether to continue or drop a course based on the student's academic progress, personal circumstances, or future course load, helping them make informed decisions.
- **Ensure students remain full time and inform them of the consequences of becoming part time:** Advisors monitor the student's course load to ensure they maintain full-time status, explaining the academic and financial implications of dropping below the full-time threshold.
- **Sign-off on applications for Pittsburgh exchange:** Advisors review and approve Pittsburgh exchange applications, ensuring students are making informed course choices and that their academic plan remains aligned with graduation requirements.
- Check-in on students with low mid-semester grades, and help with recovery plans.
- If a student is on probation, make sure they are meeting the requirements in their probation letter.
- Be a point of contact for other instructors regarding concerns about the student in their courses.
- Evaluating and approving units overload (see Section [Overloading](#)).
- Evaluating and approving course drop, withdrawal, and pass/fail (see Section [Dropping, Withdrawing, pass/failing a course](#))
- Enable the use of vouchers to drop or pass/fail courses (see Section [Vouchers](#)).

- Inform the Associate Area Head and Area Head of any scheduling conflicts, waitlisted courses, or unavailable courses that would prevent the student from graduating on time.
- Validate that all requirements are being fulfilled for the student to graduate in their senior year.
- Advise on academic actions at the end of each semester.

Additionally, academic advisors try to be mindful of other struggles students may be facing, and so may act as a bridge to other resources on campus. Each section below describes other departments and resources on campus that advisors can choose to refer their students to. It is important to note that there may be intersections in the kind of help that students get from each department and the academic advisor. At the moment, there are no reporting rules for advisors to know whether the student has actually reached out to other resources or not, but they are free to follow up with each department and the student about it.

The following figure is a summary of the available resources and their roles.



1.1 Academic Resource Center (ARC)

The Academic Resource Center organizes workshops and provides assistance in courses by hiring course assistants or through their own tutors. Students could be referred to ARC for:

- Workshops on practical skills; e.g., these are some workshops ARC has offered in the past:
 - Note taking: Getting more from lectures by taking better notes
 - Time management: Mapping your semester for balance & success
 - QPA forecaster
 - How to improve your performance by examining returned tests
 - Planning effective study sessions
 - Get organized with google calendar
- Help with entry level Math and Programming courses.
- Finding CA jobs.

Main Contact: ARC Director, currently Mariamma Thomas (mariammar@qatar.cmu.edu).

1.2 Student Affairs

Student Affairs addresses all non-academic aspects of student life at CMUQ. Students could be referred to Student Affairs in the following situations:

- Paperwork for residency, visa, and travel.
- Housing for international students.
- Exceptional financial support.
- Activities, events, clubs.
- Community standards violations.

Main Contact: Student Affairs Director, currently Dalia Rehal (drehal@andrew.cmu.edu).

Contact person for Financial Aid is Sheila Ryan (srian@qatar.cmu.edu).

1.2.1 Health and Wellness

This department provides support to students in relation to various physical or mental health concerns.

Physical Health, Main Contact: Amie Rollins (Amier@andrew.cmu.edu).

Mental Health, Main Contact: Atorina Benjamin (atorinab@qatar.cmu.edu).

1.2.2 Careers Office

Careers Office could be helpful by helping the students with:

- Writing CVs and resumes.
- Preparing for interviews.
- Connecting with potential employers.
- Career fairs.
- Internship opportunities.
- Logistical career advice.
- Graduate studies options around the world.

Main Contact: Senior Career Consultant, currently Mohammed Mirza (mohammem@qatar.cmu.edu).

1.3 Support for Student Success

Students struggling to keep up with course work, or those that require closer attention due to other challenges they are facing, can be directed to Damian Dourado (ddourado@qatar.cmu.edu). These are some examples of how he can help the students to get back on track:

- hold regular meetings;
- keep closer track of progress in course work;
- set up checkpoints and reasonable goals;
- inform students of university processes (forms for different purposes, causes and consequences of probation or suspension, possible options for failing courses, among others).

Please understand that the advisor remains as the main point of contact for academic guidance. If you think a student needs extra support due to other challenging circumstances, you may suggest this to the student, and contact Damian. When contacting Damian, please cc the Associate Area Head. Here is a

sample email message that can be sent to the student with Damian and AAH in CC (feel free to change as you wish):

Dear X,

My role as your academic advisor is to ensure that you are making progress in the Information Systems major. I have noticed that you have been struggling to keep up with the course work which has been negatively impacting your performance and hence your progress.

I believe that you would highly benefit from a more personalized help with your academic work. Hence, I am referring you to Damian Dourado (cc'd in this message), CMUQ's Director of Student Academic Success, who can coach you on how to be more effective with the load. Damian will contact you for an initial meeting so that he can learn more about you and explain how he can help.

1.4 Associate Area Head and Area Head

For truly exceptional cases, for example, when students will delay graduation, if they have disappeared or become unresponsive, or if they are underperforming consistently despite being made aware of the available support, the associate area head and area head can be contacted. Upon being informed of the student's situation, they can brainstorm solutions and propose exceptions if they are warranted. They can also contact the student to be yet another person voicing concerns and nudging the student in the right direction. If needed, they can also involve the Associate Dean for Education, currently Dudley Reynolds (dreynolds@cmu.edu).

2 IS Requirements

The best way to check the progress of a student regarding their requirements for the major, minor, or concentration is through [Stellic](#).

Even if the student has not yet declared a minor or concentration, they are able to add the requirements of the chosen program to their Stellic page, and it will automatically check which requirements are already fulfilled with the courses taken or planned by the student so far. To add a minor or concentration, the student or advisor can go to the student's page, and click on "+ add program" at the top, and a search box will appear. Programs that are only added on Stellic but not officially declared will have the tag "Not Declared" next to it.

Unfortunately, double counting rules for minors (and concentrations) in Stellic are almost all wrong. We are working to inherit the audits from Pittsburgh to fix this. In the meantime, always double check in the minor information or with the minor advisor. If you find inconsistencies between what Stellic is computing and what the official requirement states, please contact the Associate Area Head.

2.1 IS Students

The official requirements for a student to graduate with a bachelor's degree in Information Systems are detailed here: [Official requirements - BS in Information Systems](#)

The following is an overall summary of the requirements:

- 360 units to graduate
- Technical Core: 1 Mathematics & 3 Computer Science courses
- 8 core courses & 3 breadth courses
- General Education (aka [GenEd](#)):
 - 6 Foundations requirements
 - 5 Disciplinary Perspectives requirements
 - 2 Special Seminars requirements
- [Minor](#) or [Concentration](#)

2.1.1 Foundations requirement

Six requirements designed to build essential competencies:

- 9 units each at least:
 - Communication
 - Data Analysis
 - Computational Thinking
 - Contextual Thinking
 - Intercultural and Global Inquiry
 - Scientific Inquiry

2.1.2 Disciplinary Perspectives requirement

Five requirements providing broad knowledge across disciplines:

- 9 units each at least:
 - Humanities
 - Social Sciences
 - The Arts
 - Logic/Mathematical Reasoning

- 6 additional units from one of the following:
 - Design
 - Business
 - Engineering

2.1.3 Special Seminars requirement

Focuses on transformative learning experiences:

- 9 units each at least:
 - Grand Challenge Seminar
 - Perspectives on Justice and Injustice

2.1.4 Minors

- Information on available minors and how to apply, including self-defined minor: <https://scotty.qatar.cmu.edu/academic-services/minor-information/>.
- The student should figure out if they need to declare a minor (no hard deadline) or apply to a minor (check deadline). They should talk to the minor advisor.
- The process is to fill out and submit the form found at the Scotty link above.
- Once the minor is declared, you and the student will be able to see it on both S3 and Stellic (or the "Not Declared" tag on Stellic will disappear).
- Minors as Concentrations:
Students may be approved to substitute a concentration with an approved minor.
The current list of approved minors that can substitute for a concentration at CMU in Qatar includes:
 - Minor in Computer Science
 - Minor in Economics
 - Minor in Computational Biology
 - Minor in Technology Entrepreneurship (available only in Qatar)
 - Minor in Business Administration (constrained to specific courses; [see Appendix for details](#))

2.1.5 Concentrations

As part of the BSc. in Information Systems, students must complete a concentration, which provides specialized knowledge in a particular area of study.

What is a concentration?

- A concentration consists of:
 - Three advanced 9-unit courses (27 units).
 - One summative 9-unit project course or an equivalent advised research experience.
- Students may also substitute an approved minor or second major for a concentration.
- Typically, concentrations are completed during the 3rd and 4th years of study.

The departments in the Dietrich College of Humanities and Social Sciences offer the following concentrations ([Undergraduate Concentrations](#)):

- IS Concentrations (CMU in Qatar):
 - Data Science
 - Digitalization
 - Information Security and Privacy
- IS Concentrations (Pittsburgh Campus):
 - Data Analytics
 - Health Information Systems
 - Technology & Arts Enterprises
 - Technology & International Development
 - User Experience (UX) Design

Others are doable with a semester in Pittsburgh; this requires careful planning with your advisor.

To declare a concentration, students must email the Academic Program Manager at the Academic Affairs Office in CMUQ (currently Jarrin Nevel – jfn@andrew.cmu.edu) to add the concentration to their record on S3. A concentration is considered officially declared only when it is added to S3.

More information can be found in the [IS Concentrations: Information and Guidelines](#) document for specific course fulfillments.

2.2 Non-IS Students

2.2.1 IS Minor / Additional Major in IS

- Information Systems is not available as an additional major or minor.

2.2.2 Dual Degree in IS

- Yes, it is possible for students to double major within Carnegie Mellon Qatar in computer science and information systems, or business administration and information systems. Students should expect an additional year of study in order to complete requirements. Students must start with one major during their first year and then petition to double major.

3 Essential Information

3.1 Definitions

- Pass/Fail: A student can change a course to Pass/Fail before the pass/fail deadline for the semester.
- Passed units: Total units counting towards 360 unit graduation requirement.
- Factorable units: units counted towards QPA calculations.
- Full Time student: A student is considered full-time if taking 36 units or more. This number includes units in mini-courses.

3.2 Quick References

- Scotty: <http://scotty.qatar.cmu.edu>
 - [Cross registration](#)
 - [Minors](#)
 - [Forms](#) (and where to submit them)
 - [CMUQ policy for changing majors](#)
- [CMUQ Academic Calendar](#)
- [Stellic](#) (for program requirements, unofficial)
- [S3](#) (official registration information, called SIO for the students)
 - To quickly see all your advisees' grades (mid-semester and final), go to "Campus Life" (top right) and "Advising Roster".
- [CMU Policy on Grading](#)
- [CMU Policy on Course Adds, Drops, Withdrawals & Voucher Elections](#)
- [Official requirements - BS in Information Systems](#)
- [Schedule of Classes](#)

3.3 Managing Courses

3.3.1 Dropping, Withdrawing, Pass/Failing

A drop equals the course and its load "vanishing". Any other option, where a letter grade is assigned (A to R, X, P, N, I), is counted in the "load". Now, for those counted in the load, only A to R, and X are factorable, which means they have quality weights that enter the QPA calculation. The other grades are not factorable and do not impact the QPA (but count towards the load).

Dropping

A dropped course disappears from the student's transcript. If a student wants to drop a course, here are some things for you to consider:

- Will the student become part-time? (Students can be part time with an exception from the Associate Dean for Education. If they go part time without such an exception, they will go on probation.) Approval is not common.
- How does the course affect student progress towards the major? Can the student drop a different course that has fewer effects?
- Dropping a course because the student will not be getting an A (or B... or C) requires a reality check with the student. Try to discourage them from "QPA Sculpting", especially when it will impact their future semesters.
- Dropping and Withdrawing before the deadlines can be done by the student themselves on S3. (Unless they are a freshman, then ask them to email Jarrin and copy their advisor.)
- Dropping a course with a pending or reported academic integrity violation is prohibited. (New rules effective 26 Aug 2024.)

Withdrawing

- After the drop deadline, the student can still withdraw from the course by the 10th week of classes (check [calendar](#)). Withdrawing after that deadline is not allowed (even with a voucher).
- Withdrawn courses are still in the transcript, with grade W.
- Withdrawn courses count as units taken in the semester.
- Withdrawing from a course with a pending or reported academic integrity violation may be possible with a series of approvals. (New rules effective 26 Aug 2024.) To do that, please consult with Dina Al-Abdi (Office of Community Responsibility Academic Integrity Liaison).

Pass/failing

- P/N courses will count towards the total number of units.
- P/N courses will not count for any major or minor requirements.

3.3.2 Vouchers

Each undergraduate student receives three vouchers for their time at CMU. The voucher allows a student to drop or P/NP a course up until the last day of classes. The student can use only one voucher in any semester.

The deadline for using a voucher is set and enforced by the registrar in Pittsburgh and is not flexible. You can't "back date" the request after the deadline like you can with some forms.

Instructions:

- A student wishing to drop a course after the deadline must first consult with their academic advisor. It is important to note that vouchers are not intended to be used for exceptional or extenuating circumstances.
- After consultation, the academic advisor will initiate a drop voucher request in S3.
 - S3 → Student Page → Academic Records → Registration: Student Registration → Click on the wheel by the course name.
- After the request is initiated by the advisor, the student will receive an automated email requesting that they confirm the voucher information is correct within SIO (by selecting 'Official Schedule' under the 'Registration' tab, and clicking 'Confirm Drop'). The student will have 24 hours to confirm the drop; otherwise, the course will remain on their record.

Please note that students who face family, health or other personal crises will be considered on an individual basis as they are today and will not be required to use a voucher for such emergencies.

3.3.3 Course repeats

- Only one set of units of a course counts for graduation requirements.
- Some repeats may count as separate courses (e.g. independent studies and thesis).

3.3.4 Waitlists

- Cleared in the beginning of the semester by associate area head.
- Students are placed on waitlists to give priority to other students (in major, for example).
- You, the advisor, can see the waitlist and roster for any class in S3. This can help you give your students an idea of where they sit and their chances of getting in. You can also email the AAH for a given program and just ask them their opinion on the waitlist for a given course.
- If a student needs an overload or has a schedule conflict, they cannot be automatically added to a course they were waitlisted for. In this case, if they are allowed in the course, they will receive

an email with an invitation to solve the conflict and register. Note that there will be a deadline for registering.

3.3.5 Overloading

Definition: Overloading refers to taking more than the equivalent of 5 full-semester courses in the Fall or Spring semester, typically registering for more than 52 units in a semester.

- **Exceptions:**
 - StuCo (Student College) courses and Physical Education courses are not counted toward this limit.

Approval Process:

Students who wish to overload must:

1. Consult their IS Advisor to discuss their plan.
2. [Review the policy and complete the Dietrich College Petition to Carry an Overload form.](#)
3. Schedule an appointment with the IS Academic Advisor for final review and approval.

Important Notes:

- Meeting eligibility requirements does not guarantee approval to register for an overload.
- Typically, students will be allowed to overload by no more than one additional full-semester course, or its equivalent.
- If a standard 5-course load exceeds 52 units, overloads to accommodate the additional units will generally be permitted.

Students are encouraged to plan carefully and consult their advisor before requesting an overload.

3.4 Special Courses

3.4.1 Independent Studies

Independent studies allow IS majors to advance their knowledge in specific areas of interest under faculty supervision.

- **Credit Options:**
 - Students can enroll for **3, 6, 9, or 12 units** of academic credit.
 - Course numbers:
 - **67-390 and 67-393** (regular independent studies)
 - **67-391** (for late enrollments after the add deadline)
 - The course section is determined by the faculty sponsor.
- **Approval Process:**
 - **Find a faculty sponsor** to guide the study, define its academic scope, and evaluate progress.
 - **Complete and submit the application form** to an IS advisor (Brandy Wilson, Correy Dandoy, or Gary DiLisio – Hamburg Hall 3031).
 - An IS advisor will **add the course to your schedule** upon approval.
- **Requirements to Receive Credit:**
 - The research area must be **related to information systems**.
 - The faculty sponsor must be **affiliated with the IS Program**.
 - The application must be submitted by the **end of the first week of classes**.
 - Assignments, due dates, progress reviews, and grading criteria must be **established before submission**.

- Students must be **enrolled in the independent study course** while conducting the work.
- Regular contact with the faculty sponsor is expected, requiring a **serious commitment**.

Students interested in independent studies should proactively arrange their project and maintain consistent engagement with their faculty mentor.

3.4.2 StuCo Courses

- Up to 9 credits counts towards 360 units.

3.4.3 Cross Registration

- See: <https://scotty.qatar.cmu.edu/academic-services/cross-registration/>
- Cross-registration is open to full-time students at the sophomore level and higher.
- Full-time students may cross-register for one course per semester.
- When cross-registered, students must adhere to the host school's academic calendar (start date, drop/withdrawal deadlines, final exam, etc.).
- The final grade that the host school reports will appear on the home transcript.
- The final grade will factor into the student's QPA.

If a student wants to use a cross-registered course for one of their requirements, they need to provide the syllabus of the course and get authorization from the Area Head, who works with Pittsburgh to make sure the course fulfills the expectation of the category.

3.5 Probation, Suspension, or Expulsion

- Causes: lack of progress towards the degree, QPA, Academic Integrity, fall below full-time, or other severe violations.
- QPA-related:
 - Probation if 1.75 or less in Freshman year, or below 2.0 in other semesters.
 - A student goes on suspension if already on probation and semester QPA is below 2.0.
- Progress related guidelines (this is not an automatic probation, depends on case):
 - Has not finished all core 100 level courses by the end of sophomore year;
 - Has not finished all core 200 level courses by the end of junior year;
 - Has attempted core courses twice and not passed (if a student drops a course in the beginning of the semester, it is not a real attempt).

3.6 Changing Major

- See: <https://scotty.qatar.cmu.edu/cmug-policy-on-changing-majors/>
- Ask students to coordinate with the associate area head of the destination major.
- Official applications are processed at the end of year only, but in practice students can start working towards the destination major prior to transfer (as long as the destination major agrees).
- Students cannot be on probation to officially transfer.
- Until an official transfer is in place, the home major advisor is still the primary advisor. The advisor is responsible for:
 - verifying that the student is in touch with the destination major AAH (e.g. confirmation email from AAH);
 - informing the student that, until the transfer takes place, they are still in the original major and should be aware of any delay expected if they choose to continue with the original major, or are not admitted to the destination major.

3.7 Alternative Majors

If a student cannot finish their original major, but they have enough credits and courses in other topics, they might benefit from graduating in a student-defined major or bachelor's in general studies. For more information about those options, check the links below.

- Bachelor's in General Studies: [Interdisciplinary Programs < Carnegie Mellon University](#)
- Student Defined Major: [Undergraduate Options < Carnegie Mellon University](#)

3.8 Campus exchange

- Qatar students are allowed, but not guaranteed, one semester in Pittsburgh.
- Qatar students are allowed any number of summers in Pittsburgh.
- Exchange happens through an application process that starts around the middle of the semester before the exchange semester.
- There is no fixed criteria but in general:
 - Students are in good academic standing.
 - Students have an application that is thoughtful.
 - Normally we only allow Juniors and Seniors.
 - Space limits from Pittsburgh.
- When going to Pittsburgh, advisors should recommend courses that are not offered in Qatar.

3.9 Declaration and Certification on S3

This is a summary of who checks requirements, certifies programs, and adds information on S3.

Minors

- *Who adds?* Qatar Academic Program Manager (aka Jarrin)
- *Who checks requirements?* Minor advisor (advisor in S3)
- *Who certifies?* Qatar Academic Program Manager

Concentrations

- *Who adds?* Qatar Academic Program Manager
- *Who checks requirements?* Associate Area Head (aka Giselle -- advisor in S3), with the support of Concentration Directors
- *Who certifies?* Qatar Academic Program Manager

University Honors

- *Who checks requirements?* Qatar Academic Program Manager
- *Who adds?* Qatar Academic Program Manager

College Honors

- *Who checks requirements?* Area Head (aka Khaled) and Associate Area Head
- *Who adds?* Dean of Education (aka Dudley)

4 The Marianna Brown Dietrich College of Humanities and Social Sciences

4.1 Leadership

- Richard Scheines: Bess Family Dean
- Sharon Carver: Associate Dean for Educational Affairs
- Joseph E. Devine: Associate Dean for Undergraduate Studies
- Kelli Maxwell: Associate Dean for Student Success

More information: [Dietrich College Website](#)

4.2 Academic Programs

The Dietrich College of Humanities and Social Sciences offers undergraduate programs in various fields, including:

- **Disciplines:**
 - English
 - History
 - Information Systems
 - Languages, Cultures, and Applied Linguistics
 - Philosophy
 - Psychology
 - Social and Decision Sciences
 - Statistics & Data Science
 - Carnegie Mellon Institute for Strategy and Technology

The college also offers:

- Student-defined majors
- Interdepartmental majors
- Intercollege Bachelor of Humanities and Arts program
- Honors and pre-professional programs

4.3 Educational Philosophy

Dietrich College encourages interdisciplinary learning and hands-on experiences. Students are encouraged to explore and collaborate across fields through experiential learning opportunities such as:

- Internships
- Undergraduate research
- Study abroad programs
- Community service

4.4 Core Educational Approach

Dietrich College blends liberal arts with analytical and computational approaches. Key aspects include:

- **Grand Challenge Seminars:** Tackling real-world problems such as democracy, racism, and environmental justice through interdisciplinary perspectives.
- **General Education Requirements:** Courses tied to specific learning goals essential for careers, citizenship, and life.

- **Flexible Curriculum:** Students can explore a variety of majors and minors throughout their academic journey.

4.5 Lifelong Learning Skills

Dietrich College students develop deep disciplinary knowledge along with critical skills such as:

- Team collaboration across multiple disciplines
- Adaptability to rapidly changing knowledge landscapes
- Effective communication and critical thinking

4.6 Career Outcomes

Dietrich College alumni report success in competitive job markets, with many pursuing unique and non-traditional career paths. Among the class of 2022, **94%** found employment, entered graduate school, or pursued other interests such as volunteering or military service.

5 Known Issues & Feedback

The systems used for advising and university processes are not perfect. This section collects issues we have found, and suggestions for improvement when possible.

5.1 S3/SIO

- Counting the 360 units for graduation in S3 is wrong. (E.g. StuCos and Courses repeated count twice)
- Grades are not processed at the right time
- It is super slow

5.2 Stellic

- Counting the 360 units for graduation in Stellic is wrong (number of courses and units does not match those counted manually). Stellic added a "Degree Check" requirement for QIS students as a workaround. It seems to work.
- Some courses need to add the double counting manually.
- Programs in Stellic (the cards that appear when one clicks on the "Programs" link on the left menu) correspond to degrees in S3. Each program in Stellic might have different audits that apply to different students (e.g. different entry years or campus), and such audits only exist on Stellic.

5.3 University Processes

- The process of declaring minors and concentrations by sending forms and emails to Jarrin seems to be too complicated.

5.4 Program structure

Below is a list of remarks on the prerequisite structure of the IS major. We use "OFFICIAL" for [the official description](#) of the program; "STELLIC" for [the description of the Doha program in Stellic](#).